THE EV ULTIMATUM

Delhi's draft EV Policy 2.0 proposes a hard shift from petrol two-wheelers alongside wider electrification mandates. But poor charging infrastructure comes in the way of its good intentions

By **AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR** / *Graphic by* TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

DELHI'S ROADS ARE ALREADY HANDLING MORE TRAFFIC than they were built for. The National Capital Territory has 8.76 million active registered vehicles—more than 500 for every 1,000 residents—and that figure excludes the steady inflow from neighbouring districts each day. In winter, the consequences of this vehicular overload become visible in Delhi's air: vehicular emissions account for 23 per cent of its pollution, the single-largest contributor, according to a January 2026 report submitted to the Supreme Court by the Commission for Air Quality Management. What gets added next to this already saturated traffic ecosystem is now the central question shaping the Delhi government's draft Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy 2.0 for 2026–2030.

At present, the shift has only begun. Six years after the original EV policy was unveiled in August 2020, Delhi has 470,104 registered EVs—just over 5 per cent of the total vehicles. The draft policy aims to accelerate this share, combining bans with time-bound incentives. From April 1, 2028, petrol two-wheelers will no longer be registered in Delhi. That is, if the policy gets adopted as such. Commercial operators have a shorter runway: aggregators may add BS-VI two-wheelers—those compliant with India's most stringent emission standards—only until the end of 2026. (Such a ban on the induction of any new petrol/ diesel car or small cargo vehicle by aggregators has been in place since January 1 this year.) Similarly, for three-wheelers, new registrations turn electric-only from January 1, 2027. "We have a mandate to fight pollution and encourage people to shift to cleaner modes of transport, and that's what the policy is doing," says a senior government official linked to the policy formulation. "We believe the incentives proposed in the policy, including the subsidies, will help people make the choice to switch more easily."

The incentives are weighted towards early movers. Buyers of electric two-wheelers can claim subsidies of up to Rs 30,000 in the first year, which get reduced to Rs 20,000 in the second and Rs 10,000 in the third. Electric autos and small cargo vehicles are eligible for higher support (see *Decoding the Proposed EV Policy 2.0*). Scrappage incentives add another layer: retire a Delhi-registered BS-IV or older vehicle at an authorised facility and purchase an EV within six months, and there is an additional payout. Road tax and registration fees are waived, with a few exceptions.

Government departments are to transition to EVs, including those hired or leased, within six months of the policy's notification. All new buses inducted by the Delhi Transport Corporation are to be electric from that point. Schools will also have to electrify their fleets in a phased manner. "If India has to meet its net-zero emission target by 2070, Delhi must lead and achieve it by at least 2050," says Gaurav Vangaal, associate director for light vehicle production forecast (Indian Subcontinent) at S&P Global Mobility. "To do that, by 2035, the government should start paving the way for only EVs in Delhi."

Two-wheelers sit at the centre of

THE RATIONALE

Delhi has 470,104 EVs, 5 per cent of the 8.76 million active registered vehicles

At 5.93 million, two-wheelers make up 67 per cent of the vehicles; just 51,418 are pure EVs

Though the policy sets no target for EV adoption, a rapid transition to EVs in this segment is seen as the quickest way to boost it